Kurtis Gilliat

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Placement Director	Prashant Bharadwaj		prbharadwaj@ucsd.edu
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Education

University of California, San Diego 2020–Present
Ph.D. in Economics (Expected 2027)
Advisors: Gordon Dahl (co-chair), Samuel Bazzi (co-chair), Eli Berman, Itzik Fadlon

Brigham Young University 2012–2018
B.S. in Economics and Mathematics, Summa Cum Laude

Fields of Interest

Labor Economics, Political Economy, Economic History

Job Market Paper

Partisan Effects of Religious Peer Groups (with Jacob Brown)

How people shape each other's political affiliation is a central question in the social sciences—with broader implications for partisan sorting and polarization—but is difficult to answer because people select into peer groups. We study a natural experiment in which the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints periodically redraws congregation assignment boundaries, reassigning members to new church peers. Linking records on every Utah registered voter from 2012–2021 to digitized congregation maps, we employ a spatial difference-in-discontinuities design that compares changes in party registration among voters who live near one another and start off in the same congregation but are assigned to different congregations. Voters conform to their new peers: Unaffiliated voters assigned to more Republican congregations become more likely to register Republican, and Republicans assigned to more Democratic congregations become more likely to leave the party. Reassigned boundaries show no relationship with prior registration changes, supporting the design's identifying assumption. The effects are not explained by correlated peer characteristics such as race or by the partisanship of congregation leaders. Effects are strongest between demographically similar peers, the members most likely to become friends, suggesting that influence operates through personal relationships among co-congregants.

Working Papers

The Effects of Firm Closures on Worker Outcomes: Evidence from Pre-War Utah

Work in Progress

Out-Group Contact and Religious Switching

How Childhood Peer Groups Shape Long-Run Outcomes

Marriage Markets and Church Building: The Economics of Polygamy in the American West

Human Capital Beyond School: The Value Added of Non-School Institutions (with Emileigh Harrison and Anthony Yim)

How Out-Group Contact Shapes Affect and Policy Preferences (with John Holbein and Hans Hassell)

Publications

"Mortality Risk and Fine Particulate Air Pollution in a Large, Representative Cohort of U.S. Adults" (with C.A. Pope III, J.S. Lefler, M. Ezzati, J.D. Higbee, J.D. Marshall, S.Y. Kim, M. Bechle, S.E. Vernon, A.L. Robinson, and R.T. Burnett). *Environmental Health Perspectives*, 2019.

Presentations

All-California Labor Economics Conference (ACLEC)	2026
Institute for the Study of Religion, Economics and Society (IRES) Workshop	2026
BYU Economics Department Alumni Conference	2026
Association for the Study of Religion, Economics, and Culture (ASREC) Conference	2026
Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics (SOCAE)	2025
BYU Economics Department Alumni Conference	2024

Teaching Experience

University of California, San Diego

Data Analytics for Social Scientists (Associate-In)	2025
Econometrics II (TA)	2021–2025
Public Economics (TA)	2022–2024
Principles of Macroeconomics (TA)	2024
Data Analytics for Social Scientists (TA)	2023
Long Run Macroeconomics (TA)	2023
Economic History of the United States (TA)	2021

University of Chicago

Behavioral Economics (TA)	2019

Brigham Young University

International Trade (TA)	2018
Behavioral Economics (TA)	2018
Price Theory I (TA)	2016

Research Experience

University of California, San Diego

Research Assistant, Prof. Julian Betts	2022
Research Assistant, Prof. Samuel Bazzi	2022
Research Assistant, Prof. Sara Lowes	2022

University of Chicago

Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow, Prof. James Heckman	2018–2020

Brigham Young University

Research Assistant, Prof. Arden Pope	2016–2018
Research Assistant, Prof. James Cardon	2017–2018

Bates White Economic Consulting

Summer Consultant	2017

Professional Service

Co-founder/Director, Undergraduate-Graduate Economic Research Lab	2023–2025
Referee, *Journal of Development Economics*	2023
Mentor, Triton Research and Experiential Learning Scholars program	2023
Organizing Committee, Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics	2022

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

University of California, San Diego

Yankelovich Center for Social Science Research Grant	2026
UCSD Travel and Research Grant	2024
Graduate Summer Research Fellowship	2021, 2022, 2023
UCSD Travel and Research Grant	2022
Regents Fellowship	2020–2021

Brigham Young University

Economics Department Valedictorian	2018
Thomas S. Monson Presidential Scholarship	2012–2018
National Merit Scholarship	2012

Skills

Languages: English (native), Portuguese (advanced)
Software: Stata, Python, R, QGIS

References

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Samuel Bazzi (co-chair)
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